MY GRANDMA

A STORY OF HER LIFE

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On Sunday afternoons she would often go for long walks with her friends or they would go on long biking trips. But then the war came. It had ruined their fun. She couldn't go off on her bike any more in fear of the Germans and now she couldn't even wander the streets of Rotterdam because you just never know when there could be a bomb raid....

This girl was my Grandma, born in Rotterdam in Holland on March the 4th, 1924. My grandma went to public school for 7 years and 3 years to highshool. This is equivalent to grade 13 because she took more subjects including three languages: English, French and German.

Spare time was a rare thing, because she was the oldest in the family and she was the only girl. When spare time came around she went for long walks with her good friend or on Sunday they would go for a long bike ride in the country. My grandma also belonged to an exercise club and on Sunday afternoons my Grandma went with her good friend to a girls club. But of course My Grandma had to work around the house because she was the oldest. Some things she did were: cooking, washing dishes, cleaning and making beds.

My grandma's dad worked in the police force as a police detective. My grandma also had five brothers: Jaap (Jacob), Jan(John), Gerald, Cornelius and Benard(Ben).

The war was an emotional thing for my Grandma and her family because different family members were involved in it. Her dad who was a Police Detective was sent off to different concentration camps; Jaap had to go into hiding. Even my grandma was in a concentration camp for awhile.

It all started when my grandma's Dad got a call to came in for extra duty on the police force but my grandma's dad knew that they had to go round up Jews for the concentration camps. They didn't know about the extermination camps yet. Since he was a Christian he knew he couldn't go and round up Jews for the concentration camps. So he went into hiding. Only one other person on the police force went into hiding. The rest went to round up Jews for the concentration camps. When my grandma's dad was in hiding, he got involved with the underground. After being in hiding for a year he got caught and was sent to a concentration in Holland called Vught. He went through some terrible times there. He wasn't right in the camp itself but in the camp prison. My grandma's dad thought he would never be released but be executed instead. In December when the French and English offensive came closer they sent him to a concentration camp in Germany called Buchenwald. He survived Buchenwald and came home shortly after the war ended.

When my grandma's dad was in hiding my grandma, her mom and her brothers were sent to a concentration camp as hostages but were released shortly before Christmas as well

as the other prisoners who had been there for three or four months. Because the Germans get kind of sentimental about Christmas, Router who was a German and who was very high in the German S.S thought it wasn't fair to keep all these men, women and children who hadn't done anything as hostages.

After my grandma's dad had gone into hiding ,the Germans sent around these pamphlets saying that all men over the age of sixteen had to meet at the docks in one hour. My grandma's oldest brother Jaap or Jacob was sixteen so he had to go to the docks. Jaap knew that he would have to go work in the German factories.

Before my grandma's dad had gone into hiding he built a little hiding spot. The apartment buildings were much different then the ones we have here in Canada. In the Dutch apartment buildings everyone lived on a different floor. So when you came in the door on the first floor there was a long corridor or hallway and then there was the stairs. If you took away the carpet, there was a little door you could lift off to get to a small crawl space below the first floor ~~the first floor~~ where canned food and potatoes were stored. My grandma's dad made a little hiding space below the stairs.

So when Jaap had to go work in the German factories, he sat in the little hiding spot so he wouldn't have to go. There was one more floor above where grandma lived and a man who was in the underground lived there. This man also knew about the hiding spot because he shared the same stairs as

my Grandma. In the hiding spot their neighbour hid two German soldiers'uniforms, a radio, two guns, and some ammunition. Unfortunately ,he was a blabber-mouth. One time when my Grandma was eating supper, their neighbour came in and showed everyone his gun. He also blabbed to some of his friends about the hiding spot. And one day some German army trucks pulled up to the house and surrounded it. There were German soldiers on the roofs and all around the house. They went into the hallway, took out the baby carriage that was there, pulled out the carpet and searched the crawl space. They were down in the crawl space for two hours. Then they finally came up with nothing! The Germans put the carpet back and the baby carriage and went back to their trucks. The whole family thought that they would be safe but then the Germans came back in the house. They took out the baby carriage and pulled back the carpet and searched the crawl space for one more hour because they knew it had to be in there but again they could find nothing. My Grandma said that her dad was not a very good carpenter and she said you could tell where the uniforms, guns and radio were hidden in the wall. My Grandma believes that the Lord blinded the Germans' eyes so they couldn't see where the uniforms, radio and guns were hidden.

The Germans knew that the stuff must be there so they took my Grandma's brother and her neighbour prisoner. That night some people in the underground went to the prison and

got the jailkeeper to let them go because the Germans would force the information from them by gun point.

My Grandma didn't always have enough food after staying in ~~Fecth~~ Vught. Her two youngest brothers went to Frisland and stayed there with some relatives. Later her two oldest brothers in 1944 made their way to Friesland by bike and by foot so my Grandma and the family had the extra ration cards. That's how they survived the hunger year because of the extra ration cards.

My grandma's dad basically made the decision to move to Canada. He always wanted to immigrate even though he had a good job in Holland. After the war when he reported to the police force again, they said he had to sign some papers saying that he had refused to obey orders in order to be reinstated. He became very upset even though they told him not to take it so hard. This made him turn against the situation. This made him want to immigrate to Canada even more. My Grandma's oldest brother Jaap had to conscript into the army and just before they immigrated he had to go to Indonesia and he was killed in action after nine days on duty. My Grandma's other brothers were going to have to conscript into the army and in fear that they might also die in the war they decided it would be better to immigrate to Canada.

My Pake (Frisian for Grandpa) was on the same boat that my Grandma was on coming over to Canada but they never really met each other. My Pake ended up in the same area that my Grandma ended up which was the Kitchener/Waterloo area. They went to the same Church group and that's where they got to know each other better. They got married on November the 27,1948 and they immigrated in September 1947.

My Grandma and Pake came over to Canada by boat, the same boat that brought troops to Indonesia. The boat was not very nice. The women and children were in one hold and the men were in another hold. They slept in bunks that were three beds high. The name of the boat was Tabinta. This was the second boat that brought immigrants to Canada .The first boat was called the Watermon.

It was not very nice starting off in Canada, My Grandma said. In order to immigrate to Canada you had to promise to work for a farmer for one year. It was hard for my Grandmas Dad to get used to it because he always had a good job in Holland. My Pake also had to promise to work for a farmer for one year. He earned 45 dollars a month with room and board. And my Grandma's dad earned 85 dollars a month with room and board. The farmer that my Grandma's dad worked for always wanted a daughter to help in the kitchen. So my grandma worked in the kitchen and she earned 2 dollars a day. They did not treat my Grandma's family very kindly and after being there for half a year my Grandma's dad found it too strenuous. He never had a day off and he couldn't manage

it any more. After half a year they asked to be moved somewhere else. So they moved to Ridgetown and worked with a chicken farmer. The barns and the house were in such need of repair that during my great- grandparents'twenty- fifth wedding anniversary ,it was raining really hard and in one of the bedrooms, the ceiling fell right on to the bed. So the next morning my Grandma's dad asked the farmer to come take a look at the house and the farmer said," I have enough trouble in my barns so I don't have time to worry about the house."

My Grandma's dad knew a couple that had immigrated before the war and they said that they would help them find someone to stay with. They found some people on the other side of Ridgetown. And that farmer had 14 acres of tomatoes. At that time tomatoes had to be picked by hand. Everyone had to pick the tomatoes in shares. They had a tiny house which they had to make do with. Most of my Grandma's parents' furniture had to be put in storage in other Dutch families' houses because they had no room to store their furniture. Finally the year was up and my Grandma's family was on their own. They found a house to rent in Dresden. My Grandma and Pake lived upstairs and their parents lived downstairs. My Pake and my Grandma's dad and brothers worked at a factory in Dresden where they make Louisville Baseball Bats.

After making bats my Grandma and Pake moved to Wallaceburg.They lived there for two and a half years.

In April 1954, they moved to the Clinton area and

bought a fifty acre farm for $1540.00 but they couldn't make a go of it. They didn't get more than 18 cents for a dozen large eggs so they lost money because it cost more for feed. My Grandma and Pake lived by Clinton for 10 years. My Pake got into construction in Clinton and in 1964 they moved to London and Pake started to work at Althouse college and that's where they are presently living right now.

Later Dutch immigrants didn't have to work for farmers, and they had more freedom. They didn't have to commit themselves to work for such low wages for one year.

My Grandma and Pake now live a happy retired life in London and both enjoy "great" health and "great" grandchildren.